

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 11: Anshu Gupta, Goonj

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact leaders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Anshu Gupta, popularly known as the Clothing Man of India and the recipient of the 2015 Ramon Magsaysay Award, often called the Nobel Prize of Asia. Anshu is the founder of Goonj, based in New Delhi. In 1999, he quit a corporate career, and together with his wife and co-founder Meenakshi Gupta, began Goonj with items of clothing from their own wardrobe and a radical conviction that cloth is not charity — it is a matter of dignity, and a development issue. Over more than two and a half decades, Goonj has grown into one of India's most distinctive social enterprises, operating across roughly 24 states in 2024–25, channelling urban surplus material into a parallel economy of rural dignity and community-led development. Through initiatives like Cloth for Work, Not Just a Piece of Cloth, Rahat Disaster Relief and the School to School Programme, Goonj has pioneered a model in which communities are not passive receivers of aid but active agents who earn material resources through their own labour and leadership. Goonj has won the World Bank's Marketplace Award, been recognised by NASA as a game-changing innovation, and named by Fast Company among India's most innovative companies. Anshu Gupta is also an Ashoka Fellow, a Schwab Fellow, and was listed by Forbes as one of India's most powerful rural entrepreneurs.

Neharika Vohra: Anshu, it's a pleasure to have you here with us today. Thank you for joining us.

Anshu Gupta: Thank you so much. Good to be here.

Neharika Vohra: For our listeners, Anshu, could we start simply — describe what Goonj looks like today, through your eyes: its scale, the states it operates in, the range of its initiatives, the nature of your team and volunteer network, and how it's funded.

Anshu Gupta: Our dream was always something closer to a movement, and I think we're moving in that direction. We're now about 1,200 people full-time, and we operate across roughly 24 to 25 states — during the Covid era that went up to almost 30–31 states and union territories, and depending on disasters and need, it moves around, but on average it's usually 20-plus at any given time. We have about ten large centres where all the processing and production happens, but our real outreach is in the villages of India — which a lot of people don't realise, because unfortunately most still think we're simply in the business of collecting and distributing clothes. It's a completely different game we've been playing for 27 years now. Our biggest strength, honestly, is what we call our "do-gooders" — a large network of people in the cities, but just as deeply rooted in the villages; our volunteerism isn't confined to urban India at all.

Neharika Vohra: You said you're not just collecting clothes — what else is part of the work?

Anshu Gupta: The journey started with a piece of cloth, from understanding that more people die from lack of clothing in winter, in many countries, than from earthquakes or floods. And clothing has simply never been treated as a subject — from the Millennium Development Goals to the Sustainable Development Goals, you'll find a hundred, a hundred and fifty issues listed, but clothing is never named as one of them, even though when we talk about basic needs, we say roti, kapda, makaan — food, cloth, shelter. It's been a completely ignored, almost a non-issue, always treated as a charitable object — something you give away, or send as disaster relief. You'll notice that after almost every disaster, the very first relief material to leave people's homes is their used clothing — and there's also a telling pattern of people holding onto that material, almost waiting for a disaster to happen before parting with it. We don't often think of economic and social poverty as an ongoing disaster in its own right, or of winter itself as a kind of disaster — the world only started talking seriously about climate and temperature over the last decade or so; there simply wasn't that conversation before.

Clothing became our entry point into a much larger issue: material poverty. It isn't limited to cloth — a huge number of people fall into permanent debt cycles simply trying to buy basic material needs. A school-going child needs a bag, a notebook, a pen. Someone needs a sari, someone needs a shirt. After every disaster, we hear that every family will get 20 kilos of rice, but no one talks about a pan to cook it in, or a plate to eat from — and people end up buying those things at the cost of whatever little they have, and fall into debt. So we realised this isn't just about cloth — it's utensils, footwear, doors, windows, wash basins, carpets, unused material sitting in offices, unsold inventory, short-expiry stock, customer returns, seasonal changeover material, display items — you display one shoe in a shop, and once it's faded a little, the other can't be sold either. All of this is a huge volume of material that otherwise ends up in landfill — or, looked at differently, it's a huge, underused asset. On one side you have

enormous amounts of underutilised material; on the other, millions of people who genuinely need it; and in between sits the landfill or the dustbin. That material shouldn't go there — I might call my handkerchief, my kurta, or my chair "waste" tomorrow, but it isn't waste, it's only waste for me; that chair might have two more years of life in it. At Goonj we genuinely say: even a used commode, send it to us, we'll deal with almost any kind of material — we don't want bulky sofas, but unfortunately, everything comes anyway.

Neharika Vohra: Why do you think clothing has never really entered people's minds as an issue — why the SDGs, why does nobody think about it, given it's one of our three basic needs?

Anshu Gupta: It's a fairly mundane answer, but also a real one. If I miss lunch after breakfast, I understand hunger. If I travel somewhere without a hotel booked, I understand what it means to be without shelter. But unfortunately, most decision-makers have simply never had to think about clothing in that way — and they've made the mistake of identifying people by what they're wearing. When you go into a community and find people dressed reasonably well, your whole perception of poverty, and a range of other social issues, shifts — clothing becomes the first visible marker people judge by. Most of us haven't had to face that particular kind of deprivation ourselves — which isn't to say you need to have faced something personally to respond to it, that would be entirely the wrong conclusion — but in our day-to-day lives, we take it for granted, and end up judging people by it: if this person isn't dressed "properly," by whatever standard we've decided, they must be poor, and this becomes "my community," for whom I now design schemes.

Neharika Vohra: Very true. Given the volumes you're describing, you clearly have a very large volunteer and partner network — you couldn't do this alone. How large is it, and how did it come about?

Anshu Gupta: Honestly, we don't know exactly how many volunteers we have — over roughly the last decade, we've processed more than seven crore kilos of material, which has come through countless chains of people and collection camps. I think what worked in our favour is that, unlike a typical nonprofit engaging urban populations mainly around money, we only ever spoke about joining a movement — about motivating and informing more people. It's a fairly simple story of how it grew: if someone called wanting to give material, we'd say, wonderful, come — we made a point of never picking material up ourselves, because the whole underlying idea was to challenge the notion that giving away your own used material is a "donation." It isn't a donation, it's a discard — you're giving it because you no longer need it. Given away carelessly, it's still a discard; given decently, it becomes sharing, and you have no right to make a fuss about it, because you owe some gratitude to the people who'll actually use it — they are, in a real sense, the keepers of your emotional and material excess. So when someone travelled 30 kilometres to drop material off, we'd ask them to talk to four neighbours and bring their material along too. That's how it grew — one neighbour led to a collection camp in the colony, which led to that person wanting to involve their college, school or office, and along the way they became a "do-gooder," earning real respect in their own neighbourhood — people are now known as "Goonj wale uncle," "Goonj wali aunty," "Goonj wale bhaiya," because they've become the go-to people in their area. We've never encouraged certificates for volunteering — we've always framed it simply as a forum offering people a chance to do good, since everyone wants to do good. We never tracked hours, never handed out certificates by the hour, because as citizens of this country, this is simply a responsibility — a way of paying back, in whichever currency we can. Not everyone can pay back with money, but everyone has some skill, time, energy or connection to offer.

Neharika Vohra: With fast fashion increasingly in the picture — people buying clothes for a single occasion and discarding them — has that changed what comes your way? Are you getting more material, or is more of it still ending up in landfill or hoarded?

Anshu Gupta: Honestly, it's not limited to clothes anymore — furniture, suitcases, all kinds of things. And consumption itself keeps rising — when we were growing up, a household used one LPG cylinder; now it's often four. Everything comes our way eventually. But I still think we haven't found real answers to certain gaps — when we run a campaign in a school of 3,000 children, those children between them must own at least 5,000 water bottles, but a campaign might collect only 200. What happens to the other 4,800? Why does it end up recycled as plastic scrap, or simply thrown away, when that bottle could live one more life — enjoy six months of city life, then six months of village life, before finally being recycled? The whole idea of circularity, to me, really is about the optimum use of something — a pair of jeans should be worn as jeans for as long as possible before it becomes anything else. I think what's genuinely missing is more consciousness around this — schools shouldn't celebrate collecting 200 bottles; they should be asking themselves what happened to the other 4,800. As far as we know, much of it ends up either in landfill or with a scrap dealer, for whom it's no longer a water bottle at all — just plastic, or tin.

Neharika Vohra: So what you're really saying is that we need much bolder metrics — not just "kuch de diya," something was given, and that's it.

Anshu Gupta: Absolutely. I have this conversation everywhere, including with large corporates — companies with 30,000 or 40,000 employees, celebrating six cartons of donated material. Honestly, if a team member of mine could only manage six cartons out of a base of 40,000 people, I'd tell them to go — that's simply incompetence. Look at the real potential, measure against that, and only then decide what's actually worth celebrating, rather than these small tokenistic gestures.

Neharika Vohra: Very good point. You built this organisation with your wife, Meenakshi Gupta — both a founding partnership and a personal one. How has that shaped Goonj, and what has Meenakshi brought that you couldn't have built without her?

Anshu Gupta: When we started, I'd already left my job, and someone had to keep things running at home too — I did some freelance journalism and photography for a while, but eventually stopped even that to focus entirely on this; it became a genuinely 24/7 commitment. Meenakshi joined the movement full-time a little later. Before that, I still remember driving around literally door to door in our Maruti 800 in the early days — because the first task was simply reaching a hundred people, any hundred people, so they understood who we were and what we were trying to do; we had nothing, we were operating out of our home, without even an office chair or a visiting card, no background in the sector to draw on — this was 1998, long before the sector had all the language and buzzwords it has today.

Meenakshi has really been the backbone of the whole movement — beyond her role in strategy and a great deal of the internal work of the organisation, which is now a large force of people doing what is, in many ways, quite mundane work: for 27 years, collecting all kinds of usable and unusable material from people and finding innovative ways to work with it. She's also been the one who made sure we never "flew" — never got carried away by recognition or the standing ovations that come along the way — reminding us that none of it lasts, and that none of it is about any one person; it's about the hundreds and thousands of people who trusted in what, honestly, sounded like a fairly mad idea at the start. She's also become a go-to person in her own right for a great many people — relationships that began with me have, in many cases, grown far closer to her than to me, since I tend to become quite operational quite quickly.

Neharika Vohra: With 1,200 people across 24-plus states, how does the organisation actually run day to day?

Anshu Gupta: There are really three parts to it. The first is collection and awareness, largely city-based — joint campaigns with retail chains from Whirlpool to Shoppers Stop to Raymond, mostly run by volunteers and coordinated by our team; we have eight large centres in big cities, and many smaller locations run entirely by volunteers, feeding material back to us.

The second, and most important, part is processing. The core problem with material-based work generally is that people give what they have, not what others actually need — and India is an enormously diverse country. A simple example: the four or five southern states, all bordering each other, all eat rice, but different varieties; all eat sambar, with the same base ingredients, but wildly different tastes. That diversity is beautiful, but a logistics nightmare — how do you match what's given to what's actually needed, especially in rural India? Our processing centres work very precisely on exactly that. Unfortunately, alongside some beautiful giving habits, we also see some very poor ones — we've received used sanitary pads and blood-soaked undergarments in our material — and at the other extreme, we receive completely unopened items, return gifts still in their packaging. We see both extremes, and this team works to sort, match and process it all. We've also built an entire chain of what we call cloth-based employment — not a single inch of discarded but unsoiled cloth needs to go to waste. Cotton cloth becomes sanitary pads; hosiery becomes undergarments; torn jeans become school bags; torn shirts become jholas; otherwise it becomes an aasan, a sujini, a quilt. Even buttons from torn clothes get reused — we put a few buttons, a spool of thread and a needle into family kits wherever we can.

The third group is the largest for us, though it has comparatively fewer formal staff and a much larger number of rural volunteers and partner organisations — community boards, NGOs, social entrepreneurs, units of the Indian Army, the Border Roads Organisation, panchayats, schools — a very wide, detailed web of partnerships. Their work is implementation, and implementation, for us, is never about simply distributing material — we don't distribute. Instead, for 27 years, we've done hard ground-level work that today would be called "climate" work: reviving water bodies, desilting them, building bamboo bridges, cleaning canals, digging wells, planting mangroves on a large scale — what we call Cloth for Work. The idea is that people identify the issues actually troubling them themselves; for women, that usually comes down to two things — water and access. In India, and I don't believe anywhere else either, you never see a man carrying a pot of water on his head — it's always women. So when women set priorities, water, as near and accessible as possible, always comes first, which is why we've revived so many water bodies. Communities work together on this, and instead of being paid in money, they're rewarded in kind — a shirt, trousers, jeans, whatever they've effectively earned. That's how we've dismantled charity within all this used material — and crucially, the community itself decides its own priorities, from a cremation ground to a graveyard to a playground to a water body to a mangrove plantation. We would never presume to decide that for them.

Neharika Vohra: Where do the resources for actually building these things come from?

Anshu Gupta: Take a bamboo bridge, for example — you mostly need bamboo, plenty of local labour, and some wire. Every family contributes a bamboo pole or two and a few days' labour; if a river's involved, a human chain passes stones along; sometimes a better-off farmer lends his tractor, and the village collects twenty rupees each from everyone to buy the diesel for it — full local ownership, start to finish. Through this, we've built hundreds of kilometres of roads, revived hundreds of water bodies, planted millions of trees, and built thousands of kitchen gardens — a long and ongoing list of work, because not a single one of these has happened without the community's own contribution — no charity involved. And there's a real difference that comes from that: if you simply hand someone a shirt or a pair of shoes and later claim it as yours, they have no choice but to agree. But if someone has worked to earn that same item — revived their own water body for it — and you try to claim it as yours, they'll tell you plainly: it might technically be yours, but I earned it. That's the language we're really trying to change, using material simply as the tool.

Neharika Vohra: Two things I'm curious about — from my own experience with communities, doesn't this sometimes breed resentment, or a sense of expectation? And separately, given how much direct cash and handouts exist today, where people can receive money without doing much at all — how does your model sit against that reality? I largely agree with your framing, but I wonder how village realities today complicate it.

Anshu Gupta: There's no substitute for self-respect or dignity. Charity, in whatever form it takes anywhere in the world, is fundamentally imposed — nobody actually wants it. We see this even with our own house help and drivers: everyone wants to work, nobody genuinely wants something for free. I think a large part of the prevailing narrative around this is simply our own perception. If Goonj has shown anything over 27 years, it's that millions of people are absolutely willing to work — to dig new ponds, clean acres of silted-up ones — without even knowing in advance exactly what they'll get in return, because it was never framed as a transaction: work three hours, get this much. It's a tool to keep self-respect intact — I have no right to call you gareeb, or bichara, when you have your hands, your labour, your skills. In my own family, several generations of engineers — some twenty-plus IIT Roorkee graduates alone in the last generation — and I doubt many of them were ever taught how to build a bamboo bridge, or dig a well, even though the country still very much needs those skills. I honestly haven't seen evidence that free handouts have destroyed people's willingness to work — there's certainly been a heavy push toward free distribution of everything in recent years, but what I've seen is that most people are genuinely happy to do something in exchange for something. People often tell us there are simply "no workers left in the villages anymore" — and I always remind them that what's actually changed is that labourers now understand they can't be treated a certain way anymore; if you're not willing to pay minimum wage or treat people decently, that's the real reason behind the complaint.

Neharika Vohra: You mentioned building kilometres of roads and reviving water bodies — is any of that documented?

Anshu Gupta: Everything is documented — photographs, reports, all of it. But honestly, this has been one of our real weaknesses: we haven't disseminated it nearly enough, and we feel that keenly now, because the whole point was to spread this ideology — which isn't really "our" ideology at all, it's a demonstration of people's own strength and capability. It's also a very concrete rebuttal of the narrative that people don't want to work, or don't want to contribute — this is real proof that they do; people are simply looking for the option to. We've fallen short on sharing the sheer volume of stories — the enthusiasm, the wisdom, the decision-making we've witnessed — at anything like the scale we should have.

Neharika Vohra: That's important — whenever I've thought about Goonj, I've always imagined it purely as collection, sorting and distribution — using work itself as a mechanism for that distribution isn't something I'd come across much in the popular narrative before, and it's genuinely powerful. I don't think people are useless by nature, but I do believe that simply handing people money to sit idle can become its own kind of "opium of the masses."

Anshu Gupta: That's true, but only for a small number of people — the same is true in our own homes; give anyone a chance to sleep and some will take it, but that's a small minority. For most people, self-respect matters enormously, and so does choice — we come into this world to have our own choices, and charity, by definition, doesn't give you that. In charity, the giver decides what to give.

Neharika Vohra: Which really just reinforces the existing power difference — it's imposed, not chosen.

Anshu Gupta: Exactly — charity is always imposed, when what a person actually wants is to choose. And why shouldn't they?

Neharika Vohra: I completely agree. With everything you've built, what are you most proud of?

Anshu Gupta: First, that we've been able to break a number of deeply held myths, in a fairly significant way. Second, that we've found a genuinely new currency in the market — old, discarded material that used to be seen as purely charitable is now treated

as a real currency. Third — and this gives me particular personal satisfaction — our work during Covid. We're known for disaster response, but if you look at the whole of Goonj's work over 27 years, what's honestly underappreciated is that we've quietly laid down infrastructure much like a telecom company lays fibre-optic cable — the whole grid of it. You lay that network, and then you find you can use it for far more than its original purpose. Over 27 years, Goonj has built that same grid — of relationships, logistics, community understanding, decision-making, partnerships — stretching from the biggest cities to the country's borders, across thousands of villages and hundreds of towns. When Covid hit, our traditional model — built entirely on people's old material — effectively collapsed overnight, because the material simply wasn't there. By rights, the organisation should have gone quiet for three months. But within hours we realised: the only thing we actually lacked was material. We still had the relationships, the understanding, the logistics, the partners — thousands of people who trusted us, even in the remotest villages — and that's how we started working in a completely different way, turning small villages themselves into hubs rather than routing everything through Delhi. In that period we ended up moving more than four lakh kilos of fresh fruit and vegetables, because farmers in Kolar, Karnataka were being forced to sell tomatoes for fifty paise a kilo, while in Bihar the same tomatoes were selling for four rupees — the produce was perishable, so we started paying farmers fair market rates, packing vegetables in one village, and having them delivered — as work — to neighbouring villages. It worked remarkably well. That was our first truly national disaster response, and while organisations often celebrate simply getting bigger, size can also become a liability — with a footprint that large, and the whole country roughly equally affected, deciding where your responsibility actually begins and ends becomes genuinely difficult. But the fact that we could respond at all, without having to build the logistics and relationships from scratch — because that infrastructure was already there, built over years — was a real high point for us. The scale of that disaster was unlike anything we'd faced before, but being able to do even a fraction of what was needed gave a great many of us real satisfaction.

Neharika Vohra: Managing 1,200 people and that scale of logistics must rest on two things — a sophisticated supply chain, and finance. Where does each of those come from?

Anshu Gupta: Logistics is something we largely figured out ourselves, through experience, and people who study it now tell us it's actually quite efficient and cost-effective — though it's a genuinely different kind of logistics, because the material itself is so varied, and no shipment is ever uniform, and our reach extends into very remote areas — the Bangladesh border, the Nepal border, disaster-hit zones where conventional logistics simply don't function. If there's a disaster on an island in the Sundarbans, for instance, it might mean a truck, then a smaller truck, then a boat, then a motorcycle, in sequence — we've built the capability to manage that kind of chain. The real challenge now is cost — fuel, tolls and taxes have all risen sharply, and ultimately those costs land on us. We essentially need three things: storage and processing space to collect, sort and pack material; enough people to actually work on it — a single media mention can bring a thousand new donors overnight, and most of them don't realise that every piece they give still has to be sorted by a paid person, in a paid space, and transported by paid transport, because our work doesn't end at distribution, it continues through the roads being built, the water bodies being revived, and so on; and money — our survival budget runs around 80 to 90 crore rupees a year. That's not really about how emotional the work is, it's about the sheer volume and growing need, and over the last three or four years we've run into a genuine bottleneck: once the market perceives an organisation as "big," individual donors tend to pull back, and while CSR is a good source, CSR priorities don't always align with where the need is greatest — eastern India, the Northeast, Uttarakhand, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh — and CSR funding also tends to run in short, four-month project cycles, which doesn't match the nature of this work. Before Covid, our funding mix of individuals, CSR, corporates and foundations was reasonably steady. Part of the challenge is that we've genuinely never run a fundraising appeal — if you've followed Goonj, you'll never have seen one — which may give people the impression we're self-sufficient, though we're not; we don't have any large, routine HNI support behind us, only ad hoc contributions, and we're now trying to build that muscle deliberately, because it hasn't developed on its own. Eighty to ninety crores sounds like a large sum, but relative to the scale and nature of the work, it isn't especially large — and it's genuinely catalytic capital: that money doesn't just fund distribution, it mobilises far more in material, local labour, wisdom and infrastructure — mitti, patta, bamboo — worth hundreds of crores. It's a model where a hundred rupees invested effectively produces several hundred rupees' worth of outcome.

Neharika Vohra: So is that closer to catalytic capital, in effect — and are you bringing in specialised fundraising talent, or largely managing it yourselves?

Anshu Gupta: We've never actively approached anyone for money, and were largely reactive rather than proactive for a long time — people simply came to us. Money has almost always come from individuals with genuine faith in the work; there are lovely examples — someone's daughter gets into LSR and they send Goonj ten thousand rupees in celebration, or someone upgrades from a Maruti 800 to a new car and sends a cheque out of sheer happiness. It's a reliable channel, but a reactive one, and we never built the muscle to actively ask for money in the way fundraising conversations happen today — that's a language we're still learning, and I'm sure we'll find the right person for it eventually, though the gap is starting to genuinely hamper the

work and, worse, discourage people, especially at a moment when so much in the world already feels like it's moving in a negative direction.

Neharika Vohra: In terms of compensating your team, where does Goonj stand?

Anshu Gupta: Good salaries, broadly comparable with the sector, and our minimum benchmarks are deliberately high — we've never accepted the idea that a community worker should be paid three thousand rupees a month. In the very early days, some of our field staff were earning as little as 80 rupees a day; today the equivalent role pays at least 25,000 rupees a month. Everyone now has PF, ESI, and accidental insurance — anyone not covered under ESI has at least 50 lakh rupees of accidental cover, given how physically demanding some of this work is, and we provide even a small emergency fund, around 10,000 rupees, toward funeral costs when needed. We also make a point of celebrating things that often go unnoticed — when 70–80% board results don't even register as news anymore, we still distribute laddus and publicly recognise the children of our team members who've done well, along with a small token amount toward their admission to the next class. We also run a fellowship called the Next Gen Fellowship, aimed at children of our women staff working in processing and logistics — the message to parents is that we want your children to eventually become part of the operations team themselves; your job is to see them through to graduation, ours is the fellowship in between. A good number of them are part of the team today — one woman still works with us in our tea section, and her daughter, who came up through that fellowship, is now genuinely a proud part of the team too.

Neharika Vohra: Change really can't stay confined to one domain — that's a lovely example. You essentially pioneered material as currency, building on urban surplus through community development work. How has that barter logic evolved, and what insights from that experience might others learn from?

Anshu Gupta: At the core of it is the belief that sustained charity kills people's dignity. We never set out imagining we'd be digging wells or growing mangroves — that was never the plan. It came out of a simple, almost stubborn refusal to give anything away for free, which led us to ask why communities couldn't solve their own larger issues, especially given that government schemes exist for almost everything in India. If a village builds a rough road themselves, it's far easier to later convert that into a proper government-funded road, because citizens have already taken responsibility for it — and crucially, when you build something yourself, you also maintain it. That's really where this whole approach began. A few core lessons came out of it. First, people are not sitting around waiting for charity. Second, people carry an enormous amount of wisdom already — all this talk of "we'll skill them," or the old cliché about giving a fish versus teaching someone to fish, is fairly nonsensical, resting on the assumption that people don't already know how to fish, and simply want the fish handed to them in whatever shape it comes. That belief, not assumption, is exactly why when people like us do something innovative in a city, we call it "innovation," but when a village comes up with an equivalent solution, we call it "jugaad" — when in truth, that kind of innovation is often far more significant and cost-effective, precisely because villagers don't have the money or tools to burn on experimentation the way urban innovators do. Someone repurposing an old cold-drink bottle into a tap fitting to convert a three-inch outlet is genuine ingenuity, and instead of calling it jugaad, we should be learning from it.

The lesson for us, across Cloth for Work and this whole barter-based approach, is really threefold. First, it's not only about what you give, but how you give it — and more than giving, it's about sharing. Second, nobody in this relationship should be either a donor or a beneficiary — that framing is itself a power structure. If I give, and I'm "the donor," while the community gives its time and is somehow "the beneficiary" — how does that logic hold? We're both human beings, both contributing our time; my skill and the community's skill are simply different skills, not a hierarchy, and that framing has to disappear if you want genuine stakeholdership, where you put something in, I put something in, and that's where the real change happens. Third, and very important, is genuinely valuing what a person already has — their own knowledge, often inherited from their grandparents. I think what's often missing across entrepreneurship and development work generally is exactly that — failing to make people real stakeholders in their own journey. You'll see someone design a smokeless stove — a genuinely good idea — without first asking whether it's actually needed, whether it's the community's actual priority, and whether the design is properly localised. Feeling genuinely upset about someone's eyes being damaged by smoke is a completely legitimate reaction, but that doesn't automatically make it the community's biggest problem. I had no real connection to villages growing up — I grew up in smaller towns, never a village, and neither had anyone in my family for at least a generation; we were all city people. So for me, and for many of us, villages have been the biggest university of all.

Neharika Vohra: I once visited a village in Odisha, four kilometres from a district town — I won't name it — where the beer-bottle collection economy was brutally exploitative: three truckloads of empty bottles would fetch the village only about five kilos of salt in exchange.

Anshu Gupta: That's a genuinely painful example — and it's true that a lot of exploitation of exactly that kind persists, by design, in many places; unfortunately many communities live through some version of that reality every day.

Neharika Vohra: A few more questions. One is on menstrual dignity, an area you've worked on — a topic that's remained taboo across virtually every social class and community in India, but you've brought real visibility and action to it. Could you share more?

Anshu Gupta: We started out working purely on cloth, and as we tried to understand its different dimensions, one question that came up was what women were actually using during their period — because we noticed a very acute shortage on the ground, even though, paradoxically, there was significant access and awareness elsewhere. That gap seemed like something worth addressing, so around 2004–05 I personally went looking on Google — this was before terms like "sanitary pad" or "sanitary napkin" were even widely searched; the word "tampon" barely registered as a concept in India at the time, and there was almost no research in the country on the subject, just a handful of scattered studies somewhere. It genuinely surprised me, given how much this country talks about self-help groups and microfinance and grassroots innovation — I wondered where the real gap was, why there was so little information. We started talking to people, including at our own processing centre, GCC — the Goonj Centre for Circularity — and heard directly from women there about how difficult this really was.

Around that time, travelling near Ferozabad, close to Agra, a woman shared, almost in passing, that her sister had died — the village believed it was tetanus, after using a piece of a blouse held in place with a hook, apparently reused from an old quilt. It later became clear that in the process of treatment, she'd lost her uterus, and then her life. That struck me as deeply wrong, and pushed us to travel more, talk more, and we discovered that women across the world — not only in India — were using sand, ash, jute sacking, rag, newspaper, grass, cow dung, dried leaves, even old sanitary pads, whatever could absorb or stop the flow. The taboos around it are global — this idea that a woman's body should simply "rest" during that time, sit apart, not enter the kitchen, avoid certain foods — and I came to believe that at precisely the moment women are physically most vulnerable, society finds yet another way to suppress them further, exactly because they're already vulnerable at that moment.

So we started making something ourselves, using cloth we already had — we'd recovered around 170–180 truckloads of material that had gone undistributed through various government channels, and we spent about a year and a half designing products from it, built around the principle that not a single inch of cloth should be wasted. As that work opened up, we started travelling more, talking more openly about the taboos themselves, and people say we were among the first to raise the subject publicly in that way. We developed a range of products — cotton cloth for pads, hosiery for the undergarment, with two loops so it can be held in place, and later a plastic-like flex material that lets women change and rewash even out in the field. We now do this at real scale. The good news is that the subject has genuinely opened up, and there are far more people working on it today; the less good news is that many people still treat the physical product alone as the solution. That's a mistake — this is the same country that gave out free condoms virtually everywhere, from dhabas to STD clinics, and population growth barely moved, because these are never purely medical or product problems — they're much larger societal ones, needing what we call the 4 A's at Goonj: access, affordability and action, alongside awareness. Still, the fact that the subject itself is finally open is genuinely something — we've never positioned ourselves as the face of this issue, but it's good to see real movement, including our own large-scale production of these products. There's still real work to do, though — when a company claims a product is "80% biodegradable," that's often close to fraudulent, because 80% biodegradable material wrapped in 20% non-biodegradable packaging is a bit like doing a post-mortem on wildlife today and finding polythene inside — polythene that was marketed as biodegradable, but functionally isn't.

Neharika Vohra: Big problem for India generally. Does Goonj work outside India, or is it entirely domestic?

Anshu Gupta: Largely India, though there's real interest from other countries in adopting this model — Covid delayed some of that momentum, but several countries have started their own case studies, and hopefully within the next couple of years, a few will be able to adopt versions of the model themselves. We have no plans to open our own offices abroad, since this is inherently a participatory model — the development sector in other countries should be able to take it up and adapt it locally.

Neharika Vohra: Two more questions. You had a serious accident at a young age and were told you'd never walk again, but you refused to accept that verdict. How has that personal experience shaped you as an institution-builder?

Anshu Gupta: I think, for us, the word "impossible" simply isn't part of the working vocabulary. When someone tells me proudly, "sir, I'm very honest," I remind them that honesty being unusual enough to mention as a special quality is itself a problem — honesty should be the baseline, not a virtue you announce. Similarly with dedication — if you're putting in eight or ten hours a day, that's simply what the job requires, not something extraordinary in itself; anything genuinely beyond that is different, and worth recognising. We should generally feel grateful that this work found us, rather than the other way round — our own trajectories, mine and Meenakshi's, and for many of the people who've joined us, were headed somewhere entirely different before this.

I can give you a very concrete example of institutional strength: in 2015, the same year we received the Magsaysay Award, we had a massive fire on Diwali night that destroyed our entire centre — somewhere between fifty and seventy truckloads of material gone, with ten fire brigades working from six in the evening until two in the morning. You can imagine the scale, given that Diwali is peak inflow and minimal outflow season for us. When people asked what could be done, I told them the only people who could actually control a fire like that were the firefighters — you and I can only stand and cry, so we might as well eat something while we waited. Everyone had gone home by four or five that evening, as people do on Diwali, and came rushing back with buckets. That year, because we're a community of six or seven hundred people, we'd made our own sweets rather than buying from the market — our own gulab jamuns, since market sweets were expensive and often poor quality — and after the fire, those gulab jamuns were pretty much all that was left; I remember asking someone to bring them out. A lot of people that night genuinely feared they'd lose their jobs, given how much had just been destroyed. But we split into teams — one to clean up and clear debris for the municipal trucks, another to check our smaller satellite stores in case anything could still be salvaged — and by the fourth day, our very first truck went out again: seven or eight tonnes of neatly sorted material. I remember all of us standing there watching that truck leave, in tears. That's life.

Second, we've never paid a bribe, even purely for logistics and permits — and one of the clearest memories tied to my own accident is that before any surgery, a bribe of four hundred rupees was expected, and in my case, it simply wasn't paid, because that wasn't how our family operated. I remember, even at that age, the doctor shouting at my parents, asking where the money was, and my father telling him plainly that he wouldn't be paying it — even when the doctor, right there near the operating table, asked what if the boy died. My parents, whom I later lost, still said that would simply be fate — but that this was not how we lived. That value carried straight into Goonj — there's a running joke among us now, almost universal at this point, that if a truck gets stopped at a checkpoint, we simply go and sit there, patiently, and work it out through conversation rather than a bribe, and more often than not, people eventually let it go.

Neharika Vohra: So a strong reputation genuinely works in your favour, both ways.

Anshu Gupta: It really does, for a great many people — we've simply never asked otherwise.

Neharika Vohra: I hope you continue this work for a very long time, but every organisation still needs to plan for succession. Is that already underway, and how are you approaching it?

Anshu Gupta: I travel 15 to 20 days a month, often without much access to a laptop while on the road, and the organisation runs on genuinely strong systems — collective ownership, a mix of tech and non-tech processes, and a strong shared value system, alongside solid leadership at multiple levels. One of the best parts of this whole journey is how few people have actually left — we have a good number of people who've been with us ten or fifteen years, for whom this was their very first job and has remained their space ever since; a handful have even left and come back. I think the one thing still missing is a proper institutional foundation, which tends to become a source of real difficulty for organisations like this eventually — if we tried to force that conversation prematurely, in a certain way, no one would want to fill that particular role right now. I came back into the organisation more actively and deeply during the Covid phase — when something like that happens, I get pulled back in directly; otherwise I'm more focused on the wider journey.

Neharika Vohra: When you say you travel 15 or 20 days a month, is that mostly for Goonj's work, or something else?

Anshu Gupta: Largely conversations, talks and lectures — I spend a lot of that time with younger organisations, in colleges, at seminars and conferences. I also spend a good amount of time in villages, because there's a parallel, bigger idea we're developing called Gram Swabhimaan — which is really about the narrative someone holds about themselves: I might be economically weak, but I am not poor, and no one has the right to call me that.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice — and honestly, from my own experience in villages, I've always felt "poverty" itself is something of a misnomer. Slums may carry real poverty, but even that feels like a different category — we probably need a different word altogether, rather than defaulting to "poverty" as a blanket term.

Anshu Gupta: People are economically weak, some more than others — but we've imposed such a narrow definition of it that even someone owning two acres of land can be swept into that category, purely because they don't hold a formal job.

Neharika Vohra: You work extensively with young people — those considering leaving corporate careers, or entering this kind of work more broadly. What would you want them to keep in mind if they're making that kind of switch or choice?

Anshu Gupta: First and foremost — never describe it as a sacrifice. My own story is fairly simple; the realisation came later. In 1998, when I was leaving my job — Meenakshi and I both studied at the Indian Institute of Mass Communication — I did a small calculation: our fees at the time were something like one or two thousand rupees, when, given the quality of the faculty and

facilities, they probably should have been fifty or a hundred thousand. I asked myself honestly whether my parents could have afforded that higher amount, and the truth was, probably not — though they would have tried. That was the moment I understood I was, in a very real sense, the biggest product of subsidy — and subsidy never really comes from the rich, or even from government; it comes from labourers, from whoever ultimately provides it. We were deeply privileged in that sense, even if we don't always recognise it. Every person who's passed through a government school, college or IIT has benefited from subsidy in some form; even private schools run on subsidised land and public infrastructure, one way or another. Whatever anyone builds, they should recognise how much of it rests on that foundation, because it makes everything move faster.

People often tell us we've made huge sacrifices — no big house, no this, no that — but we genuinely don't see it that way, because there's no sacrifice in pursuing your own dream, and working toward it; the only honest caveat is that there's never a guarantee, because the scale of the dream itself keeps growing. So really, no one's really at fault in either direction — my simple, humble advice to anyone considering this path is: don't come here thinking you're making some sacrifice. Have fun with it. Use whatever skills you already have, and let them pay off. Second — don't rely on Google. Whatever we've genuinely learned, we learned in the field itself, because Google reflects only a very selective slice of reality — nobody types "happy farmer" into a search bar; you'll find "farmer in distress," "farmer suicide," and it stops there, when the reality on the ground today is far more varied than that. So people genuinely need to do the groundwork — listen, and listen a great deal — and resist walking in with a ready-made "solution provider" mindset, because that mindset, on its own, isn't much use, even if it's occasionally a useful way to scale something that's already understood. There's enormous need, and enormous opportunity, for exactly this kind of work in our country — genuinely, imagine the scale of that opportunity.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely right. Well, thank you so much — it's been such a lovely afternoon speaking with you, and genuinely moving. I've learned a great deal, and I wish you and Goonj all the best. I hope we get to meet again sometime.

Anshu Gupta: Thank you.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you.